

Reading Response:

Storywell: Designing for Family Fitness App Motivation by Using Social Rewards and Reflection – Saksono et al

Summary: Main takeaways: Saksono et al. aimed to test an app called Storywell, an application designed to increase low-SES families' motivation to use health apps. They found their app to be effective at inspiring the feeling of relatedness in users, which contributed to Storywell's ability to retain users. Furthermore, they identified three types of satisfying moments that nurtured caregivers' needs for relatedness and heightened users' intrinsic motivation for using Storywell: bonding moments, discovery moments, and educating moments. These satisfying moment types allowed the authors to effectively gamify their app and provide rewards that were beneficial to users during app engagement while also encouraging continued use. **Strengths and Weaknesses:** The focus on caregiver motivation was a smart choice; based on the wireframes provided in the study, Storywell's interface evokes a children's storybook style, which a caregiver might be less drawn to when using the app independently. However, given that caregivers engage with the app alongside their children, a kid-friendly interface keeps children interested and wanting to do more, and a child's enthusiasm for the app in turn intrinsically motivates the caregiver, benefiting the whole family. Another strength of Storywell's design is its use of reflection on existing PA habits to inspire and develop personalized PA strategies. One weakness, however, is that the increased motivation result comes from a population already aware they were participating in a study, which is likely itself a motivator for app use. I also found the gamification somewhat troubling; the authors acknowledge that disruptions to consistent use — whether from seasonality, life events, busy schedules, or simply forgetting — caused users to lose motivation to restart. Given that the target population is caregivers with already demanding schedules, the app increases their cognitive load by requiring sustained effort and attention. While the gamification is motivating, it seems to function only with constant use, which raises questions about user dependency and whether Storywell cultivates healthy behavior outside of the app itself. **Questions:** Some other questions I have are: Does Storywell reveal satisfying moments or create them? Furthermore, the rewards system seems potentially dangerous and like a capitalization on the root of many addictive behaviors (ironic since they are partially trying to prevent addictive eating habits). Finally, given that they mention that “basic psychological needs like competence, autonomy, and relatedness” are nurtured, how do they ensure that autonomy is preserved, given that continued motivation comes from reliance on the app?

Reaction: Interesting: The most thought-provoking aspect of this paper was the idea that intrinsic motivation is something that can be cultivated rather than simply catered to. This reframing has meaningful implications for inclusive technology design. Specifically, I think there is something clever about using a child-facing interface — illustrated storybooks and unlockable chapters — as a mechanism for motivating caregivers. A child is likely to be genuinely excited about unlocking a new story, and that excitement becomes the caregiver's motivator, even if the caregiver would not independently seek out an app with that aesthetic (I also touched on this above). **Implementation:** I think this study suggests a design strategy worth applying more broadly: rather than designing for a single user's motivation, a system can create motivational loops between users, where one person's engagement fuels another's. For inclusive technology, this means considering the relational context of use, not just the individual experience. A design that accounts for who users are, and what those people value, may be more effective at sustaining engagement than one optimized for a single user's preferences alone.